Lesson 13 material: Grammar: Adverbs, Past Tense, Comparatives and Superlatives

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

3.3: Grammar: Adverbs

From *People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners* by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). This section: CC BY-NC-SA 4.0; authored, remixed or curated by Sara Ferguson.
Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/People_and_Places_-_An_Intermediate_Integrated-Skills_Module_for_English_Learners_(Ferguson)/03%3A_Chapter_3/3.06%3A_Section_6-
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

This lesson includes slides for classroom presentation.

(Online slides or activity: open the original page above.)

What is an Adverb?

Read the sentences below and identify the adverbs. The adverbs are giving more information (modifying) about certain words or phrases in the sentence. Which ones?

- San Diego has a very diverse population
- Immigrants to San Diego don't always speak English
- Fortunately, they are learning English
- The students in this class are learning English very quickly

Answers

- The adverb is "very" and it is modifying "diverse"
- The adverb is "always" and it is modifying "speak"
- The adverb is "fortunately" and it is modifying "they are learning English"
- The adverb is "very quickly" and it is modifying "are learning"

Why Use Adverbs?

Compare these sentences. Which sentence in each pair gives more information? What kind of information do we learn?

- Immigrants are learning English
- Fortunately, immigrants are learning English
  - Answer: In the second sentence, we learn the author's opinion
- The students in this class are learning English
- The students in this class are learning English very quickly
  - Answer: In the second sentence, we learn how the students are learning
- San Diego has nice beaches
- San Diego has incredibly nice beaches
  - Answer: In the second sentence, we learn that the beaches are not just nice but incredibly nice

Examples

Read the phrases below. What are the parts of speech of the words/phrases that are modified?

- Very diverse
- Always speak
- Fortunately, they are learning English
- Are learning very quickly
- Very quickly

Answers

- "Diverse" is an adjective
- "Speak" is a verb
- "They are learning English" is a clause
- "Are learning" is a verb
- "Quickly" is an adverb

From the example, we can say an adverb can modify a verb, a clause, an adjective, or another adverb

Read the list of adverbs below. What is a common ending for many adverbs (but not all)?

- Incredibly
- Always
- Happily

- Angrily
- Quickly
- Fast
- Early
- Never
- Sometimes
- Often
- Usually
- Sadly
- Fortunately
- Rarely
- Delightedly
- Hungrily
- Basically
- Definitely
- Probably
- Possibly
- Too
- Unfortunately
- Luckily
- Certainly
- Hardly
- Quietly

Many adverbs end with -ly. Sometimes an adverb can be created from an adjective + -ly (e.g. quick, quickly)

Adverbs of Frequency

Adverbs of frequency are used to tell how often something happens. These adverbs are usually used with simple present or simple past verbs. Which of the adverbs on the list below can be used with this sentence to give information about "how often"?

- I _____ eat breakfast
- Incredibly
- Always
- Happily
- Angrily
- Quickly
- Fast
- Early
- Never
- Sometimes
- Often
- Usually
- Sadly
- Fortunately
- Seldom
- Rarely
- Delightedly
- Hungrily
- Basically
- Definitely
- Probably
- Possibly
- Too
- Unfortunately
- Luckily
- Certainly
- Hardly

- Quietly
- Frequently
- Occasionally

Answers

- Always
- Often
- Frequently
- Usually
- Sometimes
- Occasionally
- Seldom
- Rarely
- Never

Adverbs of Manner

Adverbs of manner answer the question of "how." Adverbs of manner modify verbs and usually come after the verb. Which of the adverbs on the list below may be used in the sentences below to show how she walked or ate?

- She walked _____
- She ate _____
- Incredibly
- Always
- Happily
- Angrily
- Quickly
- Fast
- Early
- Never
- Sometimes
- Often
- Usually
- Sadly
- Fortunately
- Rarely
- Delightedly
- Hungrily
- Basically
- Definitely
- Probably
- Possibly
- Too
- Unfortunately
- Luckily
- Certainly
- Hardly
- Quietly

Answers

- Happily
- Angrily
- Quickly
- Fast
- Sadly
- Delightedly
- Hungrily
- Quietly

Comment Adverbs

Comment adverbs give the speaker's opinion about the sentence. These adverbs usually come before the sentence and are followed by a comma. Which of the adverbs on the list below can fill in the blank to show the author's opinion about arriving before the concert?

- _____, we arrived before the concert began
- Incredibly
- Always
- Happily
- Angrily
- Quickly
- Fast
- Early
- Never
- Sometimes
- Often
- usually
- Sadly
- Fortunately
- Rarely
- Delightedly
- Hungrily
- Basically
- Definitely
- Probably
- Possibly
- Too
- Unfortunately
- Luckily
- Certainly
- Hardly
- Quietly

Answers

- Incredibly
- Sadly
- Fortunately
- Basically
- Unfortunately
- Luckily
- Certainly

Videos

Watch these videos for more information about adverbs...

- What Are Adverbs?
- What is an Adverb?

Links on the original page

- Slides (Google Slides): https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1qx0PTaoGZm1dFLUvDTORjAHmEpuOf8sAvj12FHw7g-A/edit?usp=sharing
- What Are Adverbs?: https://youtu.be/_txnezQ12c0
- What is an Adverb?: https://youtu.be/L0USJe44yS4

3.4: Grammar: Identifying the Past Tense

From *People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners* by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). This section: CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.
Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/People_and_Places_-_An_Intermediate_Integrated-Skills_Module_for_English_Learners_(Ferguson)/03%3A_Chapter_3/3.4%3A_Grammar%3A_Identifying_the_Past_Tense
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Regular Past Tense

Regular verbs form past tense by adding -ed to the base form.

Example: walk----walked

If the base form of the verb ends with an e, the regular past is formed by adding -d.

Example: rake---raked

Identify the regular verbs in the past tense in the text below. Regular past tense verbs end in -ed.

Text

Between the end of the Civil War (1865) and the beginning of the Great Depression (1929), almost two million African Americans moved from the rural South to look for new opportunities. While some moved west, most of this Great Migration, as the large number of African Americans leaving the South was called, moved to the Northeast and Upper Midwest. More than two-thirds of them moved to the following cities: New York, Chicago, Philadelphia, St. Louis, Detroit, Pittsburgh, Cleveland, and Indianapolis. Many African Americans did not have money to move themselves, but factory owners and other businesses helped pay for their moves. Because of racism, African American workers still had the lower-paying jobs in steel mills, mines, construction, and meat packing. In the railroad industry, they often worked as porters or servants. In other businesses, they worked as janitors, waiters, or cooks. African American women, who faced racism and sexism, often worked as maids and domestic servants. Nevertheless, African Americans earned higher wages in the North than they did for the same jobs in the South, and found housing more easily. However, life in the city was still difficult. African Americans still experienced the higher cost of living in the North, especially in terms of rent and food. As a result, housing was often overcrowded and dirty. They still experienced racism from landlords, bankers and neighbors. So why move to the North, since the economic problems were similar to those in the South? African Americans moved for non-economic gains. In the North, they found greater educational opportunities and personal freedom. Similarly, unlike the South where African Americans often experienced violence, life in larger, crowded cities permitted African Americans to move, work, and speak freely.

Irregular Past Tense

Irregular past tense is formed by changing the spelling. Because the spelling is irregular, there is not one rule for the formation of irregular past tense verbs, and these verbs need to be learned by memory.

Examine the text again. Can you identify three irregular past tense verbs?

Check Your Answers

Regular verbs in the simple past tense are underlined below. Irregular verbs in the simple past tense are bolded.

Between the end of the Civil War (1865) and the beginning of the Great Depression (1929), almost two million African Americans moved from the rural South to look for new opportunities. While some moved west, most of this Great Migration, as the large number of African Americans leaving the South was called, moved to the Northeast and Upper Midwest. More than two-thirds of them moved to the following cities: New York, Chicago, Philadelphia, St. Louis, Detroit, Pittsburgh, Cleveland, and Indianapolis. Many African Americans **did not have** money to move themselves, but factory owners and other businesses helped pay for their moves. Because of racism, African American workers still **had** the lower-paying jobs in steel mills, mines, construction, and meat packing. In the railroad industry, they often worked as porters or servants. In other businesses, they worked as janitors, waiters, or cooks. African American women, who faced racism and sexism, often worked as maids and domestic servants. Nevertheless, African Americans earned higher wages in the North than they **did** for the same jobs in the South, and **found** housing more easily. However, life in the city **was** still difficult. African Americans still experienced the higher cost of living in the North, especially in terms of rent and food. As a result, housing **was** often overcrowded and dirty. They still experienced racism from landlords, bankers and neighbors. So why move to the North, since the economic problems **were** similar to those in the South? African Americans moved for non-economic gains. In the North, they **found** greater educational opportunities and personal freedom. Similarly, unlike the South where African Americans often experienced violence, life in larger, crowded cities permitted African Americans to move, work, and speak freely.

Find more information about the simple past tense in the second module in this series, Getting to Know You.

3.4: Grammar: Identifying the Past Tense is shared under a not declared license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3.5: Grammar: Comparative and Superlative Adjectives and Adverbs

From *People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners* by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). This section: CC BY-NC-SA 4.0; authored, remixed or curated by Sara Ferguson.
Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/People_and_Places_-_An_Intermediate_Integrated-Skills_Module_for_English_Learners_(Ferguson)/03%3A_Chapter_3/3.5%3A_Grammar%3A_Comparative_and_Superlative_Adjectives_and_Adverbs
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

This lesson includes slides for classroom presentation.

(Online slides or activity: open the original page above.)

Comparative Adjectives

Compare two nouns using a comparative adjective. Which two nouns are compared in these sentences? What is the comparative adjective?

- San Diego, CA is larger than El Cajon, CA
- Black Mountain is higher than Mount Helix

Answers

- The two nouns are "San Diego, CA" and "El Cajon, CA" and the comparative adjective is "larger"
- The two nouns are "Black Mountain" and "Mount Helix" and the comparative adjective is "higher"

Did you notice what word follows the comparative adjective?

Answer

Than

How Do We Make Comparative Adjectives?

What do you notice about this list?

- Larger
- Higher
- More diverse
- Smaller
- More populated
- More difficult
- Richer
- Easier
- More majestic
- More historical
- Deeper

Rules for Writing Comparative Adjectives

- If the word is one syllable, add -er to the end of the word
- If the word ends with -e, add -r
- If the word is one syllable and ends with CVC (consonant-vowel-consonant), double the final consonant
- If the word is two syllables, use "more" + adjective
- If the word is two syllables and ends with -y, drop the -y and add -ier
- Comparative adjectives are followed by "than"

One-syllable adjectives	Two-syllable adjectives ending with -y	Two-or-more-syllable adjectives	Irregular adjectives
Larger	Easier	More diverse	Good = better
Richer	Happier	More difficult	Far = further/farther
Deeper	Hungrier	More majestic	Little = less
Higher	Curlier	More populated	Many = more
Smaller	Bad = worse		
Bigger			

Comparative Adverbs

Read the sentences below and identify the comparative adverbs...

- I like to go hiking, but I hike more slowly than my kids
- African Americans moved to the north during the Great Migration because they could vote more freely there
- If you want to sightsee in San Diego, take a car; cars travel faster than buses in San Diego

- It takes longer to visit the zoo than to visit Balboa Park

Answers

- The comparative adverb is "more slowly than"
- The comparative adverb is "more freely"
- The comparative adverb is "faster than"
- The comparative adverb is "longer…than"

How Do We Make Comparative Adverbs?

One-syllable adverbs	Two-or-more-syllable adverbs (including -ly adverbs)
Adverb + -er + "than"	"More" + adverb + "than"

Practice Quizzes

Check your understanding of comparative adjectives and adverbs. Take practice quizzes at the websites below…

- Comparative Adjectives
- Comparative Adverbs

Superlative Adjectives and Adverbs

How are superlatives different from comparatives?

Read the sentences below and identify the superlative adjectives and adverbs…

- Cowles Mountain is the highest point in the city of San Diego
- It is also the most popular mountain for hiking
- On the other hand, Woodson Mountain is the best place to take a photo, because it has Potato Chip Rock
- You can hike most easily at Torrey Pines State Beach

Answers

- The superlative is "the highest"
- The superlative is "the most popular"
- The superlative is "the best"
- The superlative is "most easily"

How Do We Make Superlative Adjectives and Adverbs?

Examine the superlative forms below. How is the superlative formed?

- The highest point
- The most popular mountain
- The best place
- Take most easily

Adjectives with one syllable	Adjectives with two or more syllables	Adjectives ending with -y	Irregular adjectives and adverbs	Adverbs with one syllable	Adverbs with two or more syllables (including -ly)										
The highest	The lowest	The tallest	The strangest	The most popular	The most beautiful	The least challenging	The easiest	The earliest	The hungriest	The best	The worst	The least	The fewest	The farthest/furthest	Th fas

Spelling when adding -er or -est to the end of an adjective or adverb…

- For most adjectives/adverbs, just add -er or -est, e.g. darker, quicker, fastest
- If the adjective/adverb ends with e, just add -r or -st, e.g. stranger, strangest
- If the adjective ends with -y or -ly, drop the y and add -ier or -iest, e.g. uglier, ugliest
- If the adverb ends with -ly, do not add -er or -est, use "more" or "most" instead
- Use the CVC rule, one-syllable words with consonant-vowel-consonant pattern double the final consonant, e.g. hotter, hottest

Takeaways: Comparatives and Superlatives

- Comparatives are used to compare two items; superlatives compare three or more items
  - EX: Torrey Pines State Park is closer than Yosemite National Park (two parks, comparative form)
  - EX: Of all the parks in Southern California, Torrey Pines is the best (many parks, superlative form)
- Negative comparisons can be made by using "less" and "least" (instead of "more" and "most")

    - EX: Torrey Pines State Park is less crowded than Yosemite National Park
    - EX: Of all the parks in Southern California, Torrey Pines is the least crowded
- Comparatives are formed with adjective/adverb + -er + "than" or with "more"/"less" + adjective/adverb + "than"
    - Depends on the number of syllables and spelling of the word
- Superlatives are formed with "the" + adjective/adverb + -est or with "the most"/"the least" + adjective/adverb
    - Depends on the number of syllables and spelling of the word
- Irregular adjectives and adverbs
    - Good/well--better--the best
    - Bad/badly--worse--the worst
    - Little--less--least
    - Much--more--most
    - Far--farther/further--farthest/furthest
    - Early--earlier--earliest
    - "Early" is an adjective and adverb, the form is irregular for adverbs

Video

Watch this video for more explanation of comparatives and superlatives...

Practice

Practice using comparatives and superlatives. Make recommendations to your classmates about the following places in your city or area. Your instructor might have you post your recommendations on a discussion board or pass them to your classmates for comment...

- Compare two restaurants. Which one is better? Why?
- Recommend the most exciting activity for a family with kids. Explain why...
- What's the best place to see a movie in your city/area? Why?
- What sights do you recommend a tourist see when they visit? Compare two or three...
- Which city/area is the easiest for a new immigrant to move into? Why?

Links on the original page

- Slides (Google Slides): https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1vQgetiS26xXr5Zrzxp3Y55HW8YV2z2Escrw8iAFLgN4/edit?usp=sharing
- Comparative Adjectives: https://www.englishclub.com/grammar/adjectives-comparative.htm
- Comparative Adverbs: https://www.englishclub.com/grammar/adverbs-comparative.php
- Video (YouTube): https://youtu.be/U2DxNgQqDgQ